

There Is No Separation Between Vipassanā and Ordinary Daily Life

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 53:40

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the Blessed Noble and fully self-enlightened one.

Listening to the Dharma — how can we say, how would you behave in front of the Queen? I don't answer that. So, generally speaking, one has to adopt a proper posture. If you want to actually rest from your sitting, bring a chair in, not a problem.

I just thought tonight to really range around the Buddha's teachings, framing it around the Four Noble Truths and try and make a link for you between what you're actually doing here and practice in daily life, make that as clear as possible.

In the Buddha's life, he begins as an ordinary person. He belongs to the ruling caste, the Kshatriya. His father's a local governor, a local king or something, a local potentate of a particular tribe, the Sakyas, just south of Nepal. And he would have been tutored to be a warrior, basically.

In his mid-twenties he goes through what you might call an identity crisis which manifests as recognising that youth is over and ahead of him is sickness, old age and death. And mythically it's put that he's out riding and he sees these particular people and each time he asks, what is it? Because he's been guarded from this sort of stuff. And does it happen to me? That's a big one. And he also sees an ascetic sitting under a tree, which suggests that maybe there was a way out of this suffering.

So then he does what seems to have been a bit like the hippie movement of the seventies, what everybody was doing, which was to abandon the lay life and wander about as an ascetic. And he went to two teachers who both taught him how to establish these very beautiful states of mind that we call the absorption or *jhāna* and each time he's invited to teach with them but each time he refuses because something in him has not been answered. Then he tries the mortification exercises eating very little, all that sort of stuff.

After about four years of that — that's as I've read anyway, they think, these things are not absolute fact — but that he did practice heavy mortification exercises, we can take for granted, he just found it was more suffering. So it was just more suffering, and it was unworthy, and a waste of time.

So in his despair, he left his companions, they thought he'd gone soft, and sitting by the road, this woman comes along with a bit of rice pudding and sees how this bedraggled poor ascetic and instead of offering it

to the god that she was supposed to be offering it to she offers it to him and it revives him. But something happens. He remembers this occasion in childhood where he's watching his father doing the ploughing ceremony and there's something about that memory, there's something about that watching which awakens in him a possibility of another way of approaching his problem.

So the first way of getting into these *jhānas* was like an escape from life, from real life I mean the reality of ordinary daily life and just escape into yourself into these beautiful states. The problem is you have to keep coming out. And the other one was self-mortification was really the idea that the body was to blame. So the fact that we feel greed is because the body feels hungry.

So if you can push down all those appetites, then you enter into these rather relaxed, beautiful states of mind. And those of you who've done a ten-day fast or a two-week fast know that after the first two or three days, you do enter into this very easy, happy state, really. And the body doesn't need food, mainly because it's eating itself. But it's definitely a good way to purify the body. But putting that aside as a practice, it's with that childlike investigation, that childlike curiosity sits under a tree and makes the break. He leaps from being an ordinary person to being this enlightened, fully enlightened person.

We say self-enlightened because after trying everything that was on offer, it was his own experience from childhood that brought up this new way of investigating in fact probably the only way of investigating as such and that's why we say he's self-enlightened. There was nobody to show him that path so he was the one who discovered it and then propagated it.

Now once he has become awakened and he spends a couple of days two or three days probably more working out the ramifications of it, the consequence of what he's seen, of what he's experienced, just like we do. We have an experience and then we think, what the heck was that about? He then goes in search of his, well, his first idea is, who can I teach? And there's a doubt in his mind when he realizes what he's actually achieved, which is so subtle, that he doesn't think anybody will really listen to him. He's at a loss, and that's put mythically as this god Sahampati coming down, the great god Sahampati, the great Brahma Sahampati coming down, saying that there are a few people, just a little dust in their eyes. And that's his reflection, to try.

And then he thought of his teachers, but they both died. And so his next port of call was his six companions. And he walks all the way from Bodhi Gaya, right the way up to Varanasi, to Sarnath Path, which is about, I don't know how to guess, because I've done it, like I remember the distance, it must be a couple of hundred miles, a hundred or so miles. And he walks all the way up there to have a chat to these old friends.

They at first don't particularly greet him very well, because I think he's gone soft, but then recognize something's changed. And as he's talking to them, it's very interesting, he says to them, have you ever heard me talk like this before? They've had chats about the Dhamma, they've had hundreds of talks and chats towards each other and met many teachers and they know him. And he asks them after a while,

after he's began to explain the path, he says, have you ever heard me speak like this before? And it was after the first couple of talks that these ascetics, these old companions, also made these insights.

Now, the important thing about the Buddha is that he's not only the founder of this particular spiritual tradition and an exemplar, he's also the archetype. Everybody who follows this path follows the Buddha's path, follows in his footsteps.

There has to be a point in our lives when we reflect and think, well, what's all this about? We wouldn't be here. None of us would be here at all if we hadn't woken up one morning and thought, what am I doing here? Who am I? What am I doing here? What's this about? So there's that questioning about the purpose of life.

And the training is this process of self-investigation. Very simple. The investigation isn't out there. The answer doesn't lie out there for our internal problems. It lies within us. And that once we begin to practice, it affects the way we are.

Now, after he had made this great effort, awakened to the truth, the Dharma, as we say, he then goes out, he re-engages in life, he re-engages. He doesn't sit there under the tree feeling happy for himself and telling people to get on with it. I just want to be left alone, please. Leave me alone. Not available sign. Far from it, he's out there and for the rest of his life, forty-five years, he's tramping up and down. And it's not so easy.

I mean, at the beginning, he seems to gather people around him who are fervent, probably already existing ascetics, who've known him for years because he's been around. And who hear about him, two of the great ones of course were his companions Sariputta and Moggallana both of whom had been ascetics they were Brahmins by caste been ascetics for quite some time and not satisfied with their teacher had gone wandering.

And it was Sariputta who met Asaji, who was one of the companions, he said, you look bright, and you look, he says, yes, he said, who's your teacher? He said, what does he teach? He teaches, for whatever arises, let me get this right now, for whatever arises, there is a cause, and there's a cause for whatever passes away, something like that. We chant it in the morning, I should know it really. It's the first one.

Anyway, that aside, Sariputta, his curiosity is awakened and he goes to see the Buddha and eventually becomes his primary disciple. He's the one who is credited to understand the Dharma, second only to the Buddha. He was given the title of General of the Dharma. His companion, Moggallana, is the magic guy. He's the one who can do all these magical tricks. And he becomes the patron saint, you might say, of the Mahayana tradition.

Just as a little aside, Moggallana has a big problem with sloth and torpor. And he asks the Buddha what to do, and the Buddha gives him eleven things that he can do before he sleeps. He's got to rub his eyes, rub his legs, open his eyes, stand up, chant, do all sorts of things. And only after eleven different things, I think

it's eleven, he can say to himself, I am tired, I will have a rest. Now he becomes fully liberated in one week, for heaven's sake. It lasted that long.

Sariputta, who didn't ask any questions, had just got the basic grip of the practice and went off investigating. It took him two weeks. Well, there's something in that, I think. The intellectual person is often at a disadvantage because he just can't get beyond the thinking mind.

So anyway, the Buddha, the reason I tell this story is to show that the Buddha's life is the exemplum, the archetype, and it happens to us in small stages. We go on retreat, we clear some things up, we get little insights about things, but then we've got to go back, we've got to re-engage.

And in time, not immediately, in time he formulated these Four Noble Truths. And these Four Noble Truths form the basis of all forms of Buddhism. If a Buddhism doesn't have the Four Noble Truths, it's simply not Buddhism. Because although there are in time doctrinal differences, they tend to be not concerned with the root of the teaching, which is this Four Noble Truths. They tend to be concerned with the nature of consciousness and things like that.

So the first noble truth is stated very clearly, it's just the truth of suffering, the truth of *dukkha*, the truth of unsatisfactoriness. And this *dukkha* is very hard to translate because it includes the joy that we get from pleasures and the happinesses of life. So it's a word which catches any form of discontent to the most horrific anguish and despair possible to humankind, dependent on pleasure or direct painful suffering. It's the whole gamut of human misery. And it's translated in various ways. Unsatisfactoriness, lack. Somebody translates it as a lack. It used to be translated as suffering, but that's too narrow a word, really.

And he points to three reasons as to where this suffering and how it arises. And that's these three characteristics. It's the fact that things arise and pass away that makes it impossible for us to hold a moment of time to stop the world and say, I'm happy now, don't move. It just doesn't work. You can't do it. And even when you've had a great party and foolishly people say, we must have another one. No, no, no. I'm a real damp squid. So, and that's what we do. We try to hold on to it. That's what we're doing. We hold on to what gives us pleasure. And that grip, that's the cramp.

And as we've been discussing throughout the week, it has its consequences, its aftermath. It's like, it has its diseases that come afterwards, the sense of addiction to something, a compulsiveness about something. Even silly things like tea and toast, for heaven's sake, can cause enormous misery. Can't they? Absolutely. And the grief at loss, which gets worse and worse and worse the more you're attached to objects and especially people. A lot of grief, my heavens. And frustration if you don't get what you want. Especially if a person doesn't do what you want. That's very frustrating. And of course this constant underlying anxiety.

And that's of course the basis, the basic position of the self. The self knows it's going to destruct. It knows death's up there somewhere, ahead of it. Therefore, underneath everything that we are experiencing, there lies this anxiety, whether we're aware of it or not. And it surfaces when something horrible happens

to us, or nearly happens to us. So anxiety is just part and parcel. We talk about this age being the age of anxiety, but that's because this age does push us to the edge of it.

I mean, we've become such sophisticated culture, a sophisticated civilization that we don't know what we'd do if the electricity went. I mean, if you go to New Guinea and live with a tribe, they don't have electricity. They live perfectly well. But for us, it's like the end of the world if electricity goes off. We become soft in that sense. We become dependent entirely upon a standard of living which is fragile. Fragile, really. And that's what we're coming to learn, aren't we?

So these emotions these mental states all hang around this idea of pleasure and the reason we go to pleasure is because at least at that point we feel happy. Ice cream makes you happy, is great. Anything that lifts us out of the misery of life is great. And of course, why not? You go for it. And that would be the general culture of a consumerist society. It plays on that. It plays on the fact that pleasant things, pleasant experiences make you happy.

And at the extreme level, you get these extreme sports where the person puts themselves in a position where they're right there in the moment. You miss the moment, you fall off the cliff or your canoe goes under or something. And to live at that level of absolute moment to moment is quite a breathtaking thing as long as you don't think you are going to die. You wouldn't do it otherwise. But of course, that's one heck of a way to live. I presume you die of heart attack in your mid-life, trying to live at that level of intensity.

But that's why they do it, because at that intense level, there's a real being alive, being aware. And what we're trying to do is to get to that without extreme sports. We don't have to be an extreme sport person to be absolutely alive in this present moment.

And apart from this impermanence, when we actually see impermanence, when we begin to grasp impermanence, when it begins to sink into the heart, when it begins to be digested at the level deep within the heart, at that attitudinal level, then we begin to see the truth of the Buddha's phrase, there is nothing in this world worth holding on to. There's nothing in this world worth holding on to. You keep repeating that, you keep repeating that until it sinks in. And as it sinks in, there's all sorts of things can come up because there are so many things we do hold on to.

Our spouses, our partners, our children, our parents, there's a whole load of relationships that we have which we're deeply entwined and when these people disappear one way or the other through death or whatever it just leaves this sort of gaping wound doesn't it in the heart. He's left there with this gaping wound and what can you do?

Now we make the mistake of thinking that this is love but in fact it's only because of that self-definition, who I am. I am somebody's spouse. I am somebody's spouse. I am, you see, I am this person's mother, father. Those definitions of I am.

Have you read Kahlil Gibran? That beautiful Lebanese poet. Well, he talks about, just in this one case, that

children don't belong to you, they come through you. They come by way of you into the world and whatnot. And that's a lovely way to see our relationships.

So that's what seeing impermanence does. It releases us from the suffering of that grasping nature we have, which is deep within us because it's to do with me, to do with my self-definition. It's like when on a level of the body itself we define ourselves by this body we have now. So if by accident we lose our sight, it's a catastrophe for us.

If you lose a part of your legs, if you have an accident on the road and you become a paraplegic, it's like the world disappears for you. Who am I now? We heard recently, didn't we, about that young lad who got injured in the rugby and his parents finally took him to Switzerland. He'd lost his reason for being. Completely lost it. And I'm sure everybody tried to give him good reasons, but he just couldn't find it. Because he defined himself as "I am an active sports person and I win, and I score tries." These definitions that we have, they go very deep.

So when something happens to us which drags that away, which pulls us out from that self-definition, it's a catastrophe. Losing your job. I mean losing your job is hard enough, it's painful enough in terms of your economic situation and all that, but it's even worse when you've defined yourself as "I am..." Just been listening now to the news of this nurse who led a Panorama programme about looking after the elderly. They filmed it in a hospital. Did anybody see that programme? Well, anyway, she's been struck off the list of nurses on the grounds that she didn't put the privacy of the patients first. But from her point of view, of course, she'd been complaining about the situation. Nobody was listening to her. So she went undercover with the Panorama team. And you can hear from her voice that she's only just heard, I think, today sometime. She's in this huge state of shock because what's she going to do now? She's been kicked out of her own profession.

So that sense of impermanence rebounds back on this sense of self. And that's the other characteristic—this idea that things are compounded, a whole entity, but in fact whatever we investigate in our lives, whether it's what we do, whether it's the body, whether it's the mechanisms of the mind, the emotional life and all that, it's all bits and pieces, it's all compounded bits and pieces. We do have the capacity to hold it all together into a concept of "me," but then we believe that that's what I am, which is very different.

I mean, the Buddha didn't go schizophrenic when he became fully liberated. He didn't split up into pieces and collapse into pieces. In fact, if anything, he became very charismatic. There was coming out of him this entire personage which people met—obviously very impressive—but he wasn't fooled by that. He didn't think "I am this guru" or something.

So something about our relationship to the way we are, to how we experience ourselves, is to do with this self. And remember that the Buddha is not saying there is no self. He doesn't go into metaphysics. He just says, look, ask the question: who am I? Who do you think you are? And then look inward and see if there's

anything there which holds, which sustains, which you can say, "Oh, well, this is me."

And that's the technique of "not me, not mine." That I'm looking at is not a self. So the pain in my knee definitely feels like me, but when I look at it and distance from it, there is a pain in the knee. And the pain in the knee is not substantial either, because I can go into it and it dissolves into all sorts of little bits and feelings. Not only that, I haven't a clue what's happening at the chemical level anyway, or the electrical level, the nerve level. There's a whole load of stuff that the self in terms of "I" seems to take for granted, but when it actually looks into things, it discovers it actually knows nothing.

It knows very little about the body. We know it as a science. People tell us that when we breathe, oxygen comes in and carbon dioxide goes out. Well, who's experienced that? I don't believe a word of it, frankly. You'd have to prove it to me. Put a plastic bag over my head. If I'm dead in four minutes, they were right.

So it's a case of what do we know? What do we really, really know? And all we're left with is our basic experience through the senses. That's what we're left with. And then we have to begin to investigate as to whether this is actually something real, whether it's not also made up.

Now because of these two positions of "I am" and the fact that everything I am seems to be changing, it manifests in the characteristic of suffering, which is the third one. It's usually rated second, but I'm doing it this way. Now in the dependent origination, you see, that suffering comes in as thirst, desire, wanting for this sort of happiness in a wrong way. And what the Buddha points to in the second noble truth is that this is the cause of suffering. So this is the manifest cause of suffering. The underlying cause of suffering is this ignorance, is this delusion about who we are and about continuity and all that business. But it manifests as desire.

So any time we find ourselves desiring something in that compulsive way—and we know that it's a wrong desire because if it's not satisfied we feel unhappy for it in one way or the other—as soon as we see desire, we know that this is a manifestation of this essential delusion as to who I am. And it becomes really clear to you.

So he's not pointing at some metaphysical thing about not-self—"I am not-self." My old teacher, he used to say he met this fellow in India, this Indian monk, who was into not-self: "I am not a person, I am not a thing." And he had an elephant, and he didn't like to use the word "me" or "mine," so he would talk to my teacher and say, "your elephant." He always put everything in the "yours" or "his." He wouldn't use "me" or "mine." It's all real crazy stuff, actually. It's a very strange thing.

So this second noble truth of desire, the cause of suffering, makes it very simple for us actually, because every time we can feel a lack, every time we can feel a yearning—which comes up in all sorts of ways. It's not just yearning for food and money. Loneliness, a sense of yearning, nostalgia, there's a whole range of these desires that come up into the mind. And if we're sharp enough, if we stay at this level of awareness, we can see it, and we can name it.

That's one of the better points of noting: you're straight on it, you say, "That's wrong desire." And that noting, that labelling of it, that actual recognition of it, does allow us a moment of reflection. We might not—we might just say, "To hell with it, I'll have that piece of toast anyway." But it does allow us a moment of reflection. And then we realise this importance of intention.

We've got a choice. That's the point of choice, we call it a choice because there are two roads open to us. We can either indulge it and keep going down the road towards suffering, or we can let go of it and move towards the road of liberation. But in a more realistic sense, once we know where the path is, there isn't a choice. I mean really, we ought to do that which is going to lead us out of suffering and to build up the commitment to that particular path.

So that's his second noble truth. Now the third one is a very clear, direct statement: there is an end to suffering. He doesn't use the word *Nibbāna*. His whole teaching is about suffering and the end of suffering. I'm using suffering now with that huge gamut of understanding. When he reduces his stuff, he says all I teach is *dukkha* and *dukkha nirodha*—in the Pāli it's three words. He reduces his whole teaching to three words: *dukkha*, *dukkha nirodha*—suffering, unsatisfactoriness, discontent, and the end of that.

So the third noble truth is not phrased "there is this mythical place called *Nibbāna*"—this Shangri-La which you can head towards, west of Birmingham. No, it's not that at all. He says there is an end to suffering. That's just a great straightforward statement, and that's it.

And one of the words that he uses in the definition, in the approach to this, is *Nibbida*, which is weariness. That's not being fed up. That's not being bored. Weariness—it comes to you when, in a sense, you've had enough. Very old people sometimes just die just because they just had enough. They just let go. They've had enough.

One example I like to use is when little children—you've got a four or five year old and they want to play tiddlywinks or snakes and ladders. And you say, "Oh yeah, come on, let's play." So you have a great one game and then they say, "Let's have another one." And you say, "Well, just a minute, I've got to get off." I've played snakes and ladders once with a kid and that's about it. So it's that sort of weariness—one wearies of things. And that's a good sign, that's a spiritual sign, that's a spiritual indicator to the person.

It's not that they are losing their desire to live or anything like that. It's just that that way of life no longer attracts. And if we think about the stages of sainthood, there are four paths and fruits, there are four levels. The third level is known as non-returner. Now, you can think of that in this traditional Buddhist way, that when they die they don't come back to this realm. But in terms of the spiritual life, what it's saying is there is nothing in this world which attracts them anymore. They're living in this world where attachment is not possible to the sensual life because they've become weary of it. They've gone beyond seeking that sort of happiness. Which doesn't mean they don't eat and drink and do all the other things. It's just that they're no longer attached to it as a form of happiness.

When they say of somebody who's achieved the end, there's a lovely phrase: they've laid down the burden. I really like that phrase. They have laid down the burden.

And then, of course, he lays out the path. And this four things, the way he laid it out, by the way, was the way that doctors in those times worked with diseases. The disease was mentioned, was spoken—what the disease was, what was the cause of the disease, what was the prognosis, and what was the medicine to be used for the end of the disease. So he very much sees himself as a doctor of the mind, as a psychotherapist or a psychiatrist or something, and he sees himself in that role because he's about suffering.

And then we've got the Eightfold Path which he delineates, and it starts off with this Right Understanding. And this Right Understanding is exactly what we've been talking about—it's beginning to understand the three characteristics. Mainly that's what it's about.

And included in that three characteristics, remember, is this whole business of suffering, the cause of desire being the cause, and therein lies all that teaching about the dependent origination that we chant in the morning. And maybe there'll be time to look into that tomorrow. So this Right Understanding begins with first of all what you hear, and then what you think for yourself, and then what you yourself experience through the teaching. So it becomes a deeper understanding of knowledge until it becomes your own personal experience. And that's when it has obviously a greater effect. But if it stays only at that level of understanding and thinking, it never really drops, it never really moves into the attitudinal base which is where your will lies, and the will expresses itself through the heart.

And how does that attitudinal base express itself? It's always the three same examples. It's always from selfishness to generosity. So once you lose the self, you're not always feeding into the self. The self, remember—this selfishness is not to be confused with self-care. One has to eat. But whether it has to be beef stroganoff every night is another matter. Or a cheesecake. Yes, cheesecake.

So it's a case of recognising that there's a shift in our attitude, and that's another telltale to the meditator, that they're moving spiritually because their attitudes change, the way they're actually behaving changes.

There's a lovely scene in the scriptures of three fully enlightened monks living together. And they're known as the Anuruddhas. They have three separate names, but the Buddha approached them as the Anuruddhas because that was the name of the chief monk. And he asks them, "How do you live so peacefully together?" And the reply is, "Well, I say to myself, what if I put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do?"

Have you ever tried that? What if I put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do? Now, frankly, that only works if the others are saying the same thing. You can tend to be abused. So you have to bring a bit of nous to this practice. But they live peacefully by being open to what the other person wanted to do. And then obviously there was some discussion. And this other lovely thing that he says—he says they go off, and whoever comes back first sets up the table. So it's not "Well, you said you were going to do

it and I was waiting for you." It's like there was a cup that needs to be washed and everybody's waiting for somebody else to do it. So it's a case of they came back and set the table and the preparation for the meal. And then whoever was last cleaned up. Obviously, if you didn't want to be last, you had to be quicker.

So this expresses itself through this lack of selfishness and a movement towards generosity. And remember that generosity demands you lose something that you are treasuring, that you thought you would use for yourself. You're giving away some time, some time of your life for the benefit of somebody else. Or you're giving away some wealth which you've spent time earning, which you had earmarked for this special treat, and you're giving it away for somebody else.

So even through the act of generosity, there's a loss of self. Every time we do it with a proper, clean, full-hearted purpose for the benefit of the other, we're undermining the self. We're undermining the self. And at the most dramatic of that is of course when somebody gives their life away for another.

I went to Auschwitz a couple of years—last year. Last year. And just amazing, really. But in the context that we're speaking of, there's a particular Catholic priest, Father Maximilian. And the SS there decided to starve to death ten men because of some partisan activity. And one of them was crying—he had a wife and children, all this sort of stuff. So Maximilian stood forth and said he'd take his place. And they allowed him to do that. And they just shut them up in this room until they died of starvation.

So that's the greatest of all. "No greater gift has man"—that's Jesus, isn't it? "No greater gift has man than to give his life for another." So that's how far generosity can go. And I mean to do that, you really mustn't think of yourself. Something has to go.

And the other one is to move away from hatred towards love, away from aversion towards love. And that manifests in our relationships to each other. And the third one is away from cruelty towards compassion. And we're not particularly talking about torturing people, but just getting our own back, a nasty word, a cutting remark, all those little ways that we diminish other people—all that disappears and moves towards compassion.

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So these are your three big ones, but actually you can take any negative attitude and the meditation will move you towards the opposite. For instance, loneliness. Loneliness is a feeling that you're not loved, you're not wanted, you're abandoned, all that sort of stuff, and it can become very self-pitying. But if you sit with it—if you sit with the feeling of loneliness, if you sit with that feeling of being unloved and all that

sort of stuff, poor little me—when it dies away, the gift comes.

Whenever you let go of these things, there always comes up a gift. But you don't know what the gift is until you let go. It's not like you've got an old TV and you think, "Well, I'll kick this out because I know which one I'm going to get—the new plasma." It's not quite like that because you don't quite know what you're going to get. You have to give something up first.

So there you are bearing with this sense of loneliness, which for some people is of course a very deep, profound feeling driving them towards despair, and to just sit with it. When it begins to disappear, what arises is solitude. And solitude is to be perfectly happy just on one's own.

We experience it in little bits and blobs when you've had too much of people—you've got to be on your own for a little while. But that's a poor solitude. To get that solitude, you've got to have lots of people around you annoying you and an escape route. But real solitude is when you've discovered, you have engendered, you've found the love for yourself. You don't need anybody else to love you, for heaven's sake. You're all right on your own, thanks very much. And that's the purpose of sometimes being on your own and bearing with those sorts of feelings.

So this process of understanding, changing our emotional, attitudinal base comes through the practice, but it doesn't just come through sitting here. The sitting can make you sit with that loneliness and help begin to allow it to dissipate. It can sit with the aversion and allow it to dissipate. But then you get these next three active qualities—right speech, right action, and right livelihood.

Here the Buddha is saying that you've got to completely re-engage. Now in the meditation we found this place within ourselves, this sort of observation post, which is a strange place to be because we found a place within ourselves to look at ourselves, to look at this psychology. Now you can't hold that position if you engage. It's a sort of split—you're looking at yourself doing something. Now it might work for simple physical activities, like when you're doing the garden or something. You can become aware of yourself. But even there, it's not quite right.

That's not what we're trying to do when we're washing the pots or doing little jobs around here or in our life. We're not trying to be aware of ourselves doing something. We're trying to actually lose that. We're trying to give ourselves entirely to what we're doing. And before you do that, you have to make sure that you're entering into that experience which is going to be conditioning with the right attitude.

So before we go to work in the morning—you'll be getting this on my email, my monthly tip—before you go to work, there has to be a moment when you have to just reflect on what it is you're going to offer in terms of probably the best time of your life. The best energy of your life goes into work of some sort, doesn't it? The work society demands—the thirty to forty, sixty best hours of your life. You get the weekend off. So you may as well make something of it instead of going in there like a real old grump.

And what you do is you sit there and you say to yourself, "Now, what is my attitude? What attitude do I

want to engender for this work?" And it's really finding that right attitude which turns the work into a spiritual exercise.

One of the examples I used is when I was at school, we went off to work in the old—well, then there were still cotton mills, believe it or not. But there was one place I got to work, which was a cake factory. Well, a confectionery and all that sort of stuff. And they had this conveyor belt, and these little cakes came along—quite speedy. And it was lined by all these women, and they stuck me in this line. And my job was to put the cherry on top of this cake.

Well, they did move very fast, and these women, of course, whose hands were flying all over the place, were having a great chat of the day. They were talking about this and talking about that. And I was going, "Whoa, where's the next one?" And once or twice, they had to stop the machine, and the foreman got absolutely sick of me and kicked me off.

Now for me, coming out of school and all that study business, it was actually quite a relief. It was lovely—you didn't have to think for the moment, you just did this very easy job, and unlike school you came out with money at the end of the week. But of course, after a few days, jobs like that got really, really boring because you were doing the same thing all the time.

And now, of course, if I ended up in a job like that, I would see it very differently. I would say, "Well, this is a great opportunity to develop concentration—moment-to-moment concentration. What more do you want? Get the machine to go faster so I can really just be there, keep my mind absolutely on that cherry, don't move off it."

So it doesn't matter actually, when you think about it—it doesn't matter what you do or what you have to end up doing in your life in terms of your work. Even the most so-called menial task becomes meaningful depending on your attitude to it.

There were some years ago—I don't know whether they still exist—but there were some Christian, some Catholic, I think they were monks of some sort, friars of some sort, who began to do the menial tasks around the city as part of their practice. From a spiritual point of view, there's no menial task. If you're in a monastery, somebody has to clean the toilet, somebody has to sweep the streets, the paving. And in fact, every morning in some monasteries that I was in, everybody got out there. We swept leaves every morning. Every morning and every afternoon.

Because the leaves are always falling. And there was this large park area with these trees. And the reason for that was because it would give you lovely shade to do your walking meditation. And every morning we'd start at one end and go to the other end. And after lunch, one end, and we went to the other end, sweeping away. Just the same old thing.

And you had to make sure that your attitude was right. If your attitude was wrong, it was absolutely boring, terrible, miserable. "I didn't come here to sweep. I came here to become enlightened and liberated.

I came here to study the Dharma. What the hell was I sweeping for?"

So it's the same with anything you do. So the importance of this teaching is that the Buddha is not separating out the meditation from daily life. He's saying it's right in there—you've got to go right in there. And somehow you have to give yourself, no matter how unwanted, how much the job that you're doing you feel is unwanted, it's not you. The point is that this is it. This is the way it is.

That's a lovely phrase that you'll see in a lot of Buddhist writings: "This is the way it is." Stop trying to think that this is the way it should be or you want it to be. This is the way it is. And it's when we accept a situation as it is that the potential arises. So long as we're fighting the situation as it should be, then you don't get anywhere with that.

And that's not to be confused with resignation—"This is the way it is, what the hell." It's not at all. It's a case of a very positive seeing that, "Well, this is the way it is, and let's make something of it."

So the connection between the meditation and daily life lies in the fact that meditation is a time, early morning, when we set ourselves in the right mode for the day. That's what we're doing. We're recognizing that there's a level of consciousness—by which I mean a way of relating to the world—which we can establish in the morning by first of all establishing it to ourselves, within ourselves, whatever mood or state we find ourselves in.

And then to engage, so that when you're eating breakfast—like the old Zen—when you're eating, you're just eating. That's it. You're not trying to observe. You're just eating. And when you meet people, before you go to work, you put the right attitude into your heart and you run with that attitude.

That doesn't mean to say that during the day it doesn't drop or fall off or you wonder where it's gone or where you've hidden it. But every time you wake up and you realize how miserable you are, you say, "Hold on, stop—something's gone wrong here."

And the last three of the Eightfold Path are right effort, right mindfulness, and right concentration—right focus you might say. So this Eightfold Path—it's all one practice, and there's a hair's breadth of difference between the sitting posture and brushing your teeth and doing the job of work.

If there's any point where in the day you think, "Well, this isn't spiritual practice," then there's something wrong. You haven't clicked. We haven't made the connection. It's all spiritual practice. From the moment you wake to the moment you sleep, it has something to do with establishing a right relationship which will, going back to our noble truths, eventually undermine the amount of discontent we feel. And that way we're slowly moving towards a relationship with the world which is no longer causing us any problems.

The Buddha says, "The world argues with me. I don't argue with the world." Let the world argue with us. Why should we argue with the world? Just get on with it.

So that's the basic platform of all Buddhist teaching. Doesn't matter what strain of Buddhism you go to,

you'll find those Four Noble Truths. And I think the more you investigate them, the more you contemplate them—they are rooted in action. They're not rooted in philosophy. They're not rooted in some highfalutin theology or anything like that. They're rooted in an actuality of how to engage in life which is going to make us content.

I think that's really the place we're moving towards, this contentment. That's a real sign of spiritual development when you find somebody who is content, happy with the way things are, whether they are not so good or wonderful. They're just in a state of contentment.

I hope my words have been of some assistance. May you be liberated from all your suffering sooner rather than later.

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